



Don't Die Retired

Free starter plan

The 7-Day Restart Plan

One week of ten-minute movements to prove to yourself you can start



Printable, with every source listed

Whether you've always been active or never got round to it

dontdieretired.com



Welcome

The 7-Day Restart Plan

One week of ten-minute movements to prove to yourself you can start.

Retirement is a word for leaving a job, not a description of a person — and this free starter plan is written for anyone who wants to do more, not less, whether you've always been active or never got round to it.

Inside

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Print it

It's made for paper. Pin the tracker pages somewhere you'll see them every day.

Start small

Every plan has a beginner's route. Doing a little, often, beats doing a lot once.

Tick the box

A row of ticks is surprisingly powerful. It's how a habit becomes part of your life.

Version 2, October 2026. Who made this guide, the part AI played and every source are set out in the last pages. This guide is general information, not medical advice. Check with your GP or a health professional before starting a new exercise programme, especially if you have a heart condition, high blood pressure, joint problems or have been inactive for a long time. Stop and seek advice if anything hurts. © Don't Die Retired. For personal use; please don't share or resell. Thank you for supporting an independent project.

Welcome — and well done for opening this

Most people who mean to get more active never begin, because the first step looks too big. This plan makes it small: seven days, ten minutes each, nothing to buy, nothing to be good at. At the end you will know something about yourself that you cannot know today.

You do not need to be fit, thin, sporty or brave. You need a sturdy chair, a worktop or wall to hold, comfortable shoes and ten minutes. If you have knees that grumble or a back that stiffens, that is normal and you are exactly who this is for.

Before you start

If you have a heart condition, uncontrolled blood pressure, have fainted or had chest pain in the last year, have had a fall in the last six months or have been told to avoid exercise, have a quick word with your GP or practice nurse first. This is a gentle programme and most will be pleased.

Stop and rest if you feel chest pain or tightness, sudden breathlessness, faintness, or sharp pain in a joint. Call 999 (911 in the US) if chest pain does not go away, spreads to an arm, the neck, jaw or back, or comes with sweating or feeling sick, if you cannot get your breath, or if you faint. Ordinary next-day muscle ache is fine; it means you did something.

This is general information, not medical advice.

■ Day 0 — two numbers to write down

- 1 Sit-to-stand.** From a firm chair, arms crossed if you can, stand fully and sit fully as many times as you comfortably can in 30 seconds. Count them. Using your hands is allowed; note it, and do it the same way on the same chair on Day 7.
- 2 How do you feel today?** Score yourself 1 to 10, where 1 is stiff, tired and unsteady and 10 is loose and sure-footed. First instinct.

	Day 0	Day 7
Sit-to-stands in 30 seconds		
How I feel (1–10)		

01 The movements

Movement	How
Ankle pumps	Seated. Point toes away, then pull them up towards you. Slow and full.
Seated march	Seated, tall. Lift one knee a little, lower, then the other.
Knee extension	Seated. Straighten one knee until the leg is level, hold a breath, lower slowly.
Shoulder rolls	Roll shoulders up, back and down in a slow circle.
Sit-to-stand	Feet flat, slightly back. Lean forward, stand, lower slowly. Hands if needed.
Heel raises	Standing, holding support. Rise onto the toes, pause, lower slowly.
Side leg raise	Standing, holding support. Lift one leg out to the side without leaning. Lower with control.
Mini squat	Standing, holding support, chair behind you. Bend knees part way as if to sit, stand back up.
Wall push-up	Hands on wall at shoulder height, feet a stride back. Chest towards wall, push away.
Single-leg stand	Hand on support. Lift one foot a little and hold, looking at a fixed point.
Marching on the spot	Standing, hand near support. Lift knees alternately.
Walk	Indoors or out, at a pace where you could still talk.

■ Your seven days

Day 1

Ankle pumps ×10 each, shoulder rolls ×8, seated march ×20, knee extension ×8 each, sit-to-stand ×3 (10 min)

Slow counts. Today is about turning up.



Day 2

Seated march ×20, knee extension ×8 each, sit-to-stand ×4, heel raises at the chair ×8, shoulder rolls ×8 (10 min)

Lower into the chair slowly — the way down is work too.



Day 3	Sit-to-stand ×5, heel raises ×10, side leg raise ×6 each, marching on the spot 1 min, single-leg stand 5 sec each with hand on (10 min) <i>Both hands on the worktop. Nothing to prove.</i>	☐
Day 4	Mini squat ×6, wall push-up ×8, heel raises ×10, seated march ×20, sit-to-stand ×5 (10 min) <i>Mini squat: weight in the heels, chest up.</i>	☐
Day 5	Marching on the spot 1 min, indoor or outdoor walk 4 min, side leg raise ×8 each, sit-to-stand ×6 (10 min) <i>A pace where you can still talk, but not sing.</i>	☐
Day 6	Sit-to-stand ×6, mini squat ×8, wall push-up ×10, single-leg stand 8 sec each, heel raises ×12 (10 min) <i>Try the single-leg stand with two fingertips instead of a full hand.</i>	☐
Day 7	Retest: sit-to-stands in 30 seconds, and your 1–10 score. Then a 6-minute walk somewhere you like (10 min) <i>Write the Day 7 numbers in the table. Compare.</i>	☐

■ If a day goes wrong

Do the two-minute version and still tick the box: sit-to-stand ×3, heel raises ×10, march for 30 seconds, one slow breath. The habit matters more than any single day.

02 What your Day 7 numbers mean

Many people manage a few more sit-to-stands after a week — mostly practice and confidence at this stage. The feel-score often moves more. If neither moves, that is fine. Neither number is the point. The point is that you did seven days, which most people never do, and you now know the ten minutes fits in your life.

■ What next

- **Keep going with The 30-Day Restart** (£5 at dontdieretired.com/shop). It picks up exactly here: four weeks from chair to standing to walking to stairs, with a self-test at each end and a two-minute fallback for bad days.
- **Already steady on your feet?** Go straight to **Strong at 60**, our 12-week beginner strength plan for home or gym — the twice-a-week strength work that the UK Chief Medical Officers recommend and fewer than one in five over-65s in England actually do.
- **Read a story a day.** Every morning at dontdieretired.com we publish a real, sourced story of someone over 50 who started something — a marathon at 70, a doctorate at 80, a surfboard at 60 — with one small thing you can try.

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You do not have to be good at this. You just have to turn up for ten minutes, and then turn up again tomorrow.

Don't Die Retired

03 About this guide

Who made it

Don't Die Retired is an independent website, dontdieretired.com, run by its founders. We are not doctors, dietitians, financial advisers or lawyers, and this guide is general information, not medical advice.

The part AI played

This guide was researched and written with AI, directed and overseen by the site's founders. The AI drafted the text, searched for the sources and compared the guide with them. You are entitled to know that, so we say it here and not in small print.

How it was checked

The checking was done with AI. In October 2026 each source on the next pages was opened and read, and this guide was compared with it. A second, separate check then opened every one again. Between them the two checks led to 6 corrections, all made in this version.

What has not happened

No doctor, physiotherapist or other registered health professional has reviewed this guide. If one does, this page will give their name, their registration and the date. Until then, treat it as careful general information and check with your GP (family doctor) or a physiotherapist.

Version

Version 2, October 2026. Sources last opened and checked on 6 and 7 October 2026.

What changed in this version:

- The stop-and-rest advice now says when to ring 999 (911 in the US).
- The strength figure is corrected: about one in six over-65s in England does enough.
- Sources and this page added.

Found a mistake?

Rules, prices, phone numbers and research all change. If something here is wrong or out of date, email hello@dontdieretired.com. We will check it against the source, correct it and say what changed. How we work is set out at dontdieretired.com/editorial-policy.

04 Where this comes from

These are the pages and papers this guide rests on. Each one was opened and read on 6 and 7 October 2026, and the guide was compared with it. Web addresses change: if one no longer works, search for the title.

■ Activity guidelines

UK Chief Medical Officers (Department of Health and Social Care), *UK Chief Medical Officers' physical activity guidelines* (2019).

The official UK advice: some activity is better than none, no minimum session length, and strength and balance work on two days a week.

gov.uk/government/publications/physical-activity-guidelines-uk-chief-medical-officers-report/uk-chief-medical-officers-physical-activity-guidelines

NHS, *Physical activity guidelines for older adults* (reviewed 2024).

Speak to a GP first if you have a medical condition, and how to judge your pace: you can still talk, but not sing.

nhs.uk/live-well/exercise/physical-activity-guidelines-older-adults

NHS England, Health Survey for England, *Health Survey for England, 2021 part 2: Adult physical activity* (2023).

How few people do strength work: in England in 2021, 17 per cent of adults aged 65 and over met the muscle-strengthening guideline.

digital.nhs.uk/data-and-information/publications/statistical/health-survey-for-england/2021-part-2/physical-activity

■ The test and the movements

US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC), *STEADI programme, 30-Second Chair Stand* (2017).

The Day 0 and Day 7 test is a standard check of leg strength; the official version uses no hands.

cdc.gov/steady/media/pdfs/STEADI-Assessment-30Sec-508.pdf

NHS, *Strength exercises* (reviewed 2024).

The NHS's own home routine, with pictures: sit-to-stand, mini-squats, calf raises, sideways leg lifts and wall press-ups, at least twice a week.

nhs.uk/live-well/exercise/strength-exercises

■ When to stop and get help

NHS, *Chest pain* (reviewed 2023).

When chest pain is an emergency: call 999 if it does not go away, spreads to an arm, neck or jaw, or brings sweating.

nhs.uk/conditions/chest-pain

NHS, *Fainting* (reviewed 2026).

Fainting while exercising is one of the times the NHS says to call 999 rather than wait and see.

nhs.uk/conditions/fainting

American Heart Association, *Warning Signs of a Heart Attack* (reviewed 2024).

The US equivalent: the warning signs of a heart attack, and the instruction to call 911 if you have any of them.

heart.org/en/health-topics/heart-attack/warning-signs-of-a-heart-attack

Keep going

This is the start, not the finish.

Every day at **dontdieretired.com** we publish a true story of someone who began something late — and the plan behind it. New guides appear there too, and you can join the free email list at **dontdieretired.com/newsletter**.

More from the shelf

The 30-Day Restart

Ten minutes a day, chair to stairs

Strong at 60

12-week beginner strength plan

Eat Strong

Four-week kitchen planner

Sharp

8 weeks to a learning habit

The Money Reset

30-day money workbook

Second Act

90-day venture workbook



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